Count Yourself Skinny

Also by Dr. TJ Mundheim

Begin with the End in Mind

— and the free 12-week My4MLife program and its member app, at my4mlife.com

Count Yourself Skinny

You'll never count a calorie. You'll count to 32 instead.

Dr. TJ Mundheim

Author of *Begin with the End in Mind* · Founder of My4MLife

A My4MLife Field Guide

my4mlife.com · my4mlife.com/assessment

Count Yourself Skinny: You'll Never Count a Calorie. You'll Count to 32 Instead.

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Sources for the research cited in this book are listed in the Sources section at the back.

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10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

Who This Book Is For

Everyone.

My last book, *Begin with the End in Mind*, was written for people ready to commit to a full program — a voyage. This one is written for the other 90 percent of us: the people who don't want a program. Who have tried counting calories and quit. Who own a gym membership they don't use and a food scale still in the box.

If you can count to 32, you can do everything in this book. There is nothing to buy, nothing to weigh, nothing to give up, and no food you're forbidden to eat.

You're going to count a handful of simple things — and stop counting everything else.

— Dr. TJ

A note before you begin

This book is education, not prescription. Nothing in these pages replaces a licensed clinician's judgment about your spe-

cific situation. If you have a medical condition — especially diabetes, an eating disorder history, or anything affecting how and when you should eat — talk to your clinician before changing your eating schedule.

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1. The Idea

Here is the entire book in one paragraph:

Naturally skinny people are not counting calories. Most of them couldn't tell you what a macro is. But watch one eat. One bite goes in. The fork goes down. They chew — a long time. They talk. They stop when they're comfortable, not when the plate is empty. They walk places without calling it exercise. They eat at roughly the same times and don't graze in between. **Their body composition isn't the result of arithmetic on food labels. It's the result of mechanics — small, repeated, countable behaviors.**

The diet industry has spent fifty years asking you to count the hardest possible thing: calories. Calories are invisible. They require labels, apps, scales, math at every meal, and willpower at every decision. That's why calorie counting has an enormous dropout rate — not because people are weak, but because the method is exhausting.

This book asks you to count easy things instead. Chews. Hours. Steps. Minutes of morning light. Each one is a single small number, counted once, that quietly does the work calorie-counting was supposed to do.

And here's what the research suggests about small numbers: **the biggest health returns tend to come at the bottom of the curve.** The first few thousand steps look like the best bargain on the whole curve. Going from zero to something is worth more than going from good to great. You do not need to be an athlete to collect most of the prize. You need to start counting.

Why does this matter beyond the mirror? Because body composition — most simply, whether your BMI sits in the healthy range — shows up in virtually every healthspan equation there is. Carrying less excess weight means lower odds of diabetes, heart disease, joint failure, and cognitive decline. Getting skinny isn't vanity. It's the single most leveraged health project most people will ever undertake. And it turns out to be countable.

One more thing about the word on the cover. Skinny isn't just where you're going — it's how you're getting there. Look at what this program asks of you: no calorie math, no food scale, no gym membership, no forbidden-food list, no six-day-a-week anything. We took the entire bloated process of getting healthy and skinnied *it* down to a handful of numbers you can count on your fingers. **The diet industry got fat. This book got skinny. So will you.**

2. Count to 32: The Chew

Start here, because it costs nothing and starts at your very next meal.

The rule: **take one bite, put the fork down, and chew that bite 32 times before you swallow.**

Thirty-two is an old number — one chew per tooth, as the saying goes. Researchers have since put chewing itself to the test. In a small Iowa State University study of 45 adults, people who chewed each bite 50 percent more ate about 10 percent less pizza at a single lab lunch. Those who doubled their chews ate about 15 percent less. Same pizza. Same table. They chewed more, stopped sooner, and were no hungrier at the end. It was one meal, not a diet, but it's a promising place to start.

The idea is timing. Fullness signals take a while to build. A fast eater can finish the whole plate — and often seconds — before those signals arrive. A slow chewer lets fullness catch up to the fork. Researchers even have a name for the pattern they see in people who struggle with weight: big bites, few chews, short meals. The mirror image is free to try.

What to count: **32 chews per bite. Fork down between bites.**

A word about the number. Thirty-two is a limit, not a score, and more isn't better. Lost count? Swallow and take the next bite. If you have a history of disordered eating, or counting ever starts to feel like pressure, let the number go, just eat slowly, and talk with your care team.

What you'll notice within a week: meals take longer, portions shrink on their own, and food — strangely — tastes better, because it's actually in your mouth long enough to taste.

One honest note: chewing alone won't transform you. In a companion study of older adults, chewing more slowed people down but didn't change how much they ate. It's one lever in a stack. But it's the lever that trains the master skill behind every other chapter — slowing down on purpose.

> ***Tonight's count:*** *At your very next meal, count one bite out loud in your head — all 32 — with the fork on the table. One bite. That's the whole assignment.*

3. Count the Hours: The Space Between Meals

The second count is the hours between your last bite at night and your first bite the next day.

Every time you eat, insulin rises — that's its job, moving fuel out of your blood. But insulin is also the storage hormone: while it's elevated, your body is in save mode, not spend mode. Snacking and grazing keep insulin raised almost all your waking hours, which means your body rarely gets a turn to burn what it stored.

The fix is spacing, and it's counted in hours:

- **Start at 12.** Finish dinner at 7 p.m., eat breakfast at 7 a.m. Twelve hours, most of it asleep. Almost nobody finds this hard, and it already beats the modern grazing pattern.
- **Graduate to 14, then 16** when 12 feels like nothing. A 16-hour space (eating within an 8-hour window) is the top of the ladder, and it's optional. Go only as far as feels good.
- **Inside your eating window, eat meals — not a stream.** Two or three real meals, nothing in between.

Water, black coffee, and tea don't count as eating.

- **Count 3 hours between your last bite and bed.** Late eating hijacks both your sleep and your overnight fat-burning shift.

Notice what you're not doing: you're not changing *what* you eat yet. Just *when*. Hours are the easiest thing in this book to count — your phone's clock does it for you.

> ***Tonight's count:*** *Note the time of your last bite tonight. Add 12. That's breakfast. You've started.*

4. Count Your Steps

Forget, for a moment, everything you've heard about 10,000 steps.

That number traces to a Japanese business slogan and walking clubs from the 1960s and '70s. The actual research is far friendlier. A pooled analysis of 17 studies and nearly 227,000 adults found that people who walked more had lower death rates, with **the heart benefit showing up at around 2,300 steps a day** and the all-cause benefit at around 3,900. So this book's floor is 2,500 — about a mile and a quarter, twenty-odd minutes, total, in an entire day. Every extra 500 steps was linked to about 7 percent fewer heart-related deaths. These studies show a link, not proof, but it's a friendly one.

And here's the beautiful part: **the curve tends to be steepest at the bottom.** The first steps off the couch look like the best bargain on it. The person with the most to gain from this chapter is the person currently walking the least. If that's you, you are not behind — you're standing in front of the biggest bargain in all of health science.

So here's the ladder. Climb at your own pace and stop wherever life allows:

- **2,500 — the floor.** Right around where the heart benefit starts to show. A half-mile walk plus ordinary daily puttering gets you here.
- **5,000 — the habit.** Roughly where "sedentary" officially ends.
- **8,000–10,000 — the goal.** Benefits keep coming here, just more slowly.
- **14,000 — the bonus round.** For when walking has become who you are.

Your phone already counts this for you, in your pocket, free. You don't need a gym, a program, or a single minute labeled "exercise." You need to look at one number each evening and nudge it upward.

> ***Tonight's count:*** *Open your phone's health app and read yesterday's steps. Don't judge the number — just learn it. Tomorrow, beat it by 500.*

5. Count Ten Minutes: Morning Light

This is the count almost nobody knows about, and it may be the highest-leverage ten minutes of your day.

Your body runs on a master clock, and that clock is set by light — specifically, bright outdoor light early in the day. Get it, and your clock keeps good time, so melatonin rises at night to sleep you. Miss it, and the clock tends to drift later.

The dose is almost embarrassingly small. My rule of thumb: **about ten minutes outside, within an hour of waking.** Five minutes on a bright day; closer to twenty when it's heavily overcast. In one study of 109 office workers, those who got more bright light in the morning tended to fall asleep faster and report better sleep. That's a link, not a guarantee, but it's a cheap bet.

Two rules:

- **It must be outside.** Through a window, you receive a small fraction of the light your clock needs. Even a gray sky

outdoors delivers many times more light than the brightest indoor room.

- **No sunglasses for those ten minutes** (never stare at the sun — just be outside with your eyes open to the day).

What to count: ten minutes. That's it. Coffee in hand on the porch counts. Walking the dog counts. And if you're thinking "wait — couldn't I get my steps at the same time?" — hold that thought. That's Chapter 11.

> ***Tomorrow's count:*** *Coffee goes outside with you. Ten minutes, no sunglasses, within an hour of waking.*

6. Count Your Nights

Sleep is where the skinny is made, and it comes with the simplest count in the book: **nights of at least 7 hours, counted per week. Shoot for 7 out of 7.**

Short sleep is an appetite amplifier. In one small study, 12 healthy young men who slept too little for two nights had more of the hunger hormone, less of the fullness hormone, and a bigger appetite, especially for sweet and starchy foods. On average, people who chronically sleep short weigh more, and it is not a character flaw. It's chemistry. You cannot out-discipline a sleep-deprived appetite.

The good news: three counts you've already learned are secretly sleep protocols. Morning light sets tonight's melatonin. A 3-hour gap between dinner and bed means you're not going to sleep on a full stomach. Daily steps are among the best-documented sleep aids in existence. Do the day right and the night mostly takes care of itself.

Count your nights. A week with seven 7s will do more for the scale than any product ever sold on late-night television.

> ***Tonight's count:*** *Count backward 7½ hours from your alarm. That's lights out. Set a bedtime alarm for 30 minutes before it.*

7. Count Before Noon: Water First

The shortest chapter, for the simplest count: **two glasses of water before noon, the first one before your coffee.**

Thirst is a shape-shifter — it frequently shows up dressed as hunger, especially mid-morning and mid-afternoon. Two glasses first means you've answered the body's actual question before you reach for a snack.

You don't need a gallon jug with motivational markings. Two glasses, counted, before noon. Done.

> ***Tomorrow's count:*** *Put a glass next to the coffee maker tonight. It goes down first.*

8. What You'll Never Count

This chapter is the promise on the cover, so let's make it explicit. On this program you will never count:

- **Calories.** Not one, not ever. The counts in this book shrink your intake automatically; the arithmetic happens without you.
- **Macros, points, or grams.** No apps demanding you photograph your lunch. No weighing chicken breast. The food scale stays in the box.
- **Money.** Every count in this book is free. There is nothing to buy — no shakes, no wraps, no proprietary anything.
- **Reps and sets.** No gym required. Walking is the whole exercise program until you decide you want more.
- **Forbidden foods.** There is no list to memorize and nothing you can never eat again. When you chew every bite 32 times and eat inside a window, the *what* starts improving on its own — highly processed food is engineered to be swallowed fast, and it loses much of its magic at chew number twenty.

Diets fail because they demand constant accounting of invisible things. This works because it demands occasional counting of obvious things. That's the whole trick.

And that's the real meaning of the title. Skinny the process, and the body follows.

> ***Tonight's count:*** *Zero. Put the food scale in a drawer. Delete the calorie app. Enjoy it.*

9. Eating Out Without Falling Off

Restaurants are where diets go to die, because diets ask you to negotiate with a menu. The counts don't care about the menu. They travel with you.

The 32 is your armor. Order whatever you actually want — then eat it one bite at a time, fork down, 32 chews. Two things happen. First, fullness gets a chance to catch up while food is still on the plate, and you may find it easier to leave restaurant food behind. Second, you'll discover that half of what restaurants serve isn't worth 32 chews — bread service and fried sides mostly dissolve by chew fifteen, and food that disappears before you can chew it was engineered to be swallowed, not tasted.

Order first. Decide before the menu performs for you: at a sit-down place, a protein and a vegetable is always on the menu even when it isn't printed. Order first among your tablemates and you'll order what you walked in intending to eat, not what the table's momentum suggests.

The bread basket test. You don't have to refuse it. You have to chew it. One piece, 32 chews, and you'll know whether

tonight's bread is actually good — most isn't, and now it's not a temptation, it's furniture.

Mind the window. A late dinner reservation is the one real threat a restaurant poses, because it attacks the hours count and the 3-before-bed rule at once. When you control the booking, book early. When you don't, shrink the meal, chew everything, and let tomorrow's breakfast slide later. The space is the count; where you place it is yours.

And if the evening goes completely sideways — dessert, the works? You know the rule by now. Never miss twice. Tomorrow's morning walk is already on the calendar.

> ***Next restaurant:*** *Order first. Chew the bread once — 32 — and decide if it's actually good.*

10. The Grocery Cart

There's no food list in this book, but there is a cart strategy, and it's countable like everything else.

Shop the walls, count the aisles. Fresh food lives on the perimeter of nearly every grocery store — produce, meat, dairy, eggs. The center aisles are where food goes to be engineered: softened, sweetened, and processed specifically so it can be eaten fast. Here's the count: **two aisles.** Walk the whole perimeter, then allow yourself two center aisles per trip, chosen on purpose (coffee and olive oil are in those aisles too — this isn't a purity test).

Never shop hungry — and now you never have to. You have a fast clock and an eating window. Put grocery trips inside the window, after a meal. A fed shopper and a fasting shopper buy measurably different carts, and the difference is almost entirely in the swallow-fast foods.

The chew test, applied in advance. Standing in front of a package, ask one question: *will this survive 32 chews?* Foods that will — meat, vegetables, nuts, apples, real bread — are almost automatically the foods that were going to end up in the "eat more of this" chapter of every diet book ever written.

Foods that won't are the ones the 32 was designed to protect you from. You're not memorizing a list. You're carrying a filter.

Buy the week's mornings. Whatever makes the morning walk easier, stock it: the coffee you look forward to, and the eggs, fish, or meat you'll break the fast with when you walk back in. The cart's job isn't just avoiding trouble — it's provisioning the stack.

> ***Next trip:*** *Walk the perimeter first, pick your two aisles before you enter, and shop fed.*

11. One Walk, Five Boxes

Now stack them.

Everything in this book compresses into a single daily act: **the morning walk, taken before breakfast.** Out the door within an hour of waking, twenty to thirty minutes, then come home and eat.

Count what just happened:

1. **Steps** — 2,500 or more, banked before the day can interfere. ☑
2. **Morning light** — your ten minutes happened automatically. ☑
3. **Hours** — you extended last night's fast; you walked in a fasted state, when your body preferentially spends stored fat. ☑
4. **Tonight's sleep** — scheduled this morning: the light that hit your eyes on the walk sets tonight's melatonin. ☑
5. **Water** — glass one before you left, glass two when you return. ☑

Then eat your first meal the way you now eat every meal: one bite, fork down, 32 chews. Make it protein-first — eggs, fish, meat, or Greek yogurt before anything else on the plate. My rule of thumb is thirty to forty grams, and you won't weigh it: four or five eggs, or a palm-and-a-half of chicken or fish, gets you there. By 9 a.m. you have executed the entire program. Total cost: about twenty-five minutes and zero dollars.

This is why the stack beats the checklist. You are not maintaining six habits — you are keeping one appointment with yourself each morning, and the habits ride along for free.

> ***Tomorrow's count:*** *Shoes by the door tonight. Out the door within an hour of waking. Twenty minutes. Five boxes.*

12. The Streak

The final count is the one that makes the others permanent: **days in a row.**

Each evening, ask one yes-or-no question: *did I hit my counts today?* The morning walk. The 32. The hours. The nights. If yes, the streak grows by one. That's the entire tracking system — one integer.

Rules for the streak:

- **Never miss twice.** You will miss days; life happens. One missed day is a rest. Two in a row is a new habit forming in the wrong direction. Guard the day after a miss like it's the whole program — because it is.
- **Shrink the day, not the streak.** Sick, traveling, slammed? A five-minute walk and slow-chewed meals still count. The streak measures showing up, not performance.
- **Weigh once a week.** Same scale, same morning. That's my rule for this book, because one number a week is simple and the day-to-day bounce from water and food tells you very little. Research has found daily weighing works too and doesn't hurt most people's mood, so if you like it, carry on.

Just judge the trend, not the day. And if the scale ever starts running your day, put it away.

Give it twelve weeks. Not because there's anything magic about twelve, but because that's long enough for the trend line to become undeniable — and for the counting to stop feeling like counting.

> ***Tonight's count:*** *Day one starts today, not Monday. Answer the question tonight: did I hit my counts?*

13. What Comes After Skinny

Somewhere in those twelve weeks, something will shift. The scale, yes — but also the mornings, the sleep, the way your head feels at 3 p.m. And you may find yourself asking a bigger question than "how do I get skinny?"

The question is: *how do I keep this mind sharp for the rest of my life?*

That question has an answer, and it's bigger than one book of counts. It involves your gut, your hormones, your muscle, your environment, and a framework I've spent years building with a team assembled for exactly this purpose. I wrote a whole book about it — *Begin with the End in Mind* — and built the free My4MLife program around it, with its own member app and a step-by-step twelve-week voyage.

You've counted yourself skinny. When you're ready to go further:

Start with the free assessment at my4mlife.com/assessment.

It takes a few minutes, and it will tell you — specifically, for your body and your situation — what to do next.

Don't lose your identity and your dignity while you still have a choice.

Until then: fork down. Chew. Count.

— Dr. TJ

The Counts on One Page

Tear this out. Photograph it. Stick it on the refrigerator. This is the entire program.

The Count	The Number	When
Chews	32 per bite, fork down between bites	Every meal
Hours between meals	12 → 14 → 16	Overnight
Hours before bed	3 (last bite to lights out)	Evening
Steps	2,500 floor → 5,000 → 8–10,000	All day
Morning light	10 minutes outside	First hour awake
Water	2 glasses before noon, first before coffee	Morning
Nights	7 hours, 7 nights a week	Weekly
Weigh-in	Once — same scale, same morning	Weekly
The Streak	Days in a row. Never miss twice.	Daily

The stack: one morning walk before breakfast checks five boxes at once — steps, light, extended fast, tonight's sleep, and both glasses of water (one before, one after).

The promise: you will never count calories, macros, points, grams, money, reps, or forbidden foods.

Your 12-Week Count Log

You could track this program on a sticky note — it's one yes-or-no question a day. But twelve weeks of sticky notes blow away, and a trend you can *see* is the strongest motivator ever discovered. So the rest of this book is your log.

Three rules before Week 1:

1. **Fill in tonight's line tonight.** The log works when the pen hits it daily — thirty seconds, at the same time every evening.
2. **A shrunk day still counts.** Five-minute walk, slow-chewed meals on a sick day? Check the box. The streak measures showing up.
3. **Weigh in once a week.** Same scale, same morning. One number a week is plenty, so don't let a daily wobble rattle you.

Before Week 1: Your Starting Line

Fill this in once, honestly. You will love this page in twelve weeks.

	Your number today
Date	_____
Weight (same scale you'll use weekly)	_____
Typical hours between dinner and breakfast	_____
Steps yesterday (check your phone)	_____
Mornings outside in the last week	_____
Nights of 7+ hours sleep in the last week	_____

Why I'm doing this (one sentence — who do you want to be skinny *for*?):

_____

Week 1

This week's focus: the 32. *Just master the chew. Everything else is extra credit.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 12+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 2,500+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

The win this week (one line):

_____

The hardest moment, and what I'll do differently:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 2

This week's focus: the space. *Make 12 overnight hours automatic — same last bite, same first bite, every day.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 12+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 2,500+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

The win this week:

_____

The hardest moment, and what I'll do differently:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 3

This week's focus: the walk. *Make the morning walk the anchor — five boxes, one act.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 12+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 2,500+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

The win this week:

_____

The hardest moment, and what I'll do differently:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 4

This week's focus: protect the streak. *The first month closes. If you miss a day, guard the next one like it's the whole program.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 12+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 2,500+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

One month down. Compare today's weigh-in to your starting line:

_____

The win this week:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 5

This week's focus: stretch to 14. *If 12 overnight hours feels like nothing, push dinner earlier or breakfast later.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 12–14	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 5,000+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

The win this week:

_____

The hardest moment, and what I'll do differently:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 6

This week's focus: the 3-hour rule. *Last bite to lights out: three full hours, every night this week.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 12–14	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 hours before bed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 5,000+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

Halfway. Total change from your starting line:

_____

The win this week:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 7

This week's focus: taste. *You've slowed down enough to notice food again. Notice which foods stop being worth 32 chews.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 14	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 hours before bed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 5,000+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

The win this week:

_____

The hardest moment, and what I'll do differently:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 8

This week's focus: two months strong. *The counts should feel less like rules and more like reflexes. If one still fights you, make it the only focus this week.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 14	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 hours before bed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 5–8,000	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

Two months down. Total change from your starting line:

_____

The win this week:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 9

This week's focus: the 16 experiment. *Try a 16-hour space on two or three days — not every day. See how your body votes.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 14–16	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 hours before bed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 5–8,000	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

The win this week:

_____

The hardest moment, and what I'll do differently:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 10

This week's focus: someone else. *The program is now visible on you. Invite one person to Week 1. Teaching the 32 locks it in for life.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 14–16	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 hours before bed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 8,000+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

The win this week:

_____

Who I invited, and how it went:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 11

This week's focus: the maintenance question. *Which counts will you keep forever? (Hint: Week 13 and Forever, at the back of this book, makes the case for two — the walk and the 32.)*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 14–16	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 hours before bed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 8,000+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Weekly weigh-in: _____

Streak at week's end: _____

The win this week:

_____

The counts I'm keeping for life:

_____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

Week 12

This week's focus: finish loud. *Seven for seven. Then turn back to your starting line and read what you wrote.*

Count	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning walk	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
32 chews, fork down	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Overnight hours: 14–16	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 hours before bed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steps: 8,000+	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10 min morning light	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 glasses before noon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7+ hours last night	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hit my counts today	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Final weigh-in: _____

Longest streak of the twelve weeks: _____

This week's daily notes

One honest line a day — what you ate slowest, where the day fought back, what you noticed.

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

Sun _____

After Week 12: Your Finish Line

	Starting line	Today	Change
Weight	_____	_____	_____
Overnight hours	_____	_____	_____
Steps per day	_____	_____	_____
Mornings outside per week	_____	_____	_____
Nights of 7+ hours	_____	_____	_____

What I know now that I didn't know twelve weeks ago:

_____

_____

You counted yourself skinny. The next question — how to keep this mind sharp for the rest of your life — is waiting at **my4mlife.com/assessment**.

Questions People Actually Ask

Isn't "skinny" an unhealthy word? Shouldn't this book say "strong" or "well"?

I chose it on purpose, for two reasons. First, honesty. The wellness industry retired the word, but when people close the bathroom door and talk to the mirror, "skinny" is still the word they actually use — and I'd rather meet you at the word you use than at the word a marketing department approved. Second, this book means it twice. Skinny the body, yes. But mostly, skinny the *process*: this program is what's left when you strip dieting of everything that makes people quit — the counting of invisible things, the weighing, the buying, the forbidding. We skinnied the method down to numbers you can count on your fingers. If the cover made you mad enough to open the book and read this far — good. The argument the cover started, the program finishes.

Do I really have to chew everything 32 times? What about soup? Yogurt? A smoothie?

The number is a ceiling, not a law. Foods that don't need 32 chews get the *spirit* of the rule: spoon down between bites, no

gulping, let the meal take twenty minutes. But notice something — foods that require zero chewing are usually the exact foods engineered to get calories into you fastest. If most of your diet can't be chewed, that *is* the finding.

Isn't 32 chews embarrassing at a restaurant or a business lunch?

Nobody is counting your chews but you. From the outside, a 32-chewer looks like the most relaxed, unhurried person at the table — the one who puts the fork down, listens, and talks. Slow eating reads as confidence, not weirdness. You'll also notice you can actually hold a conversation now.

I skipped breakfast for years and was told it was unhealthy. Now you're telling me to delay it?

The breakfast-is-mandatory rule came from an era that also recommended margarine. What matters is the *space* — the consecutive hours your body spends not digesting. Whether you create that space by finishing dinner early or starting breakfast late is personal preference. Pick the end of the day you control.

Coffee. Please tell me coffee doesn't break the fast.

Black coffee doesn't meaningfully break the fast. Neither does tea or water. A splash of milk is a gray zone; a 400-calorie caramel drink is breakfast. Rule of thumb: if it requires a straw and a dome lid, it's a meal.

What if I work nights?

The clock shifts; the counts don't. "Morning light" means light shortly after *your* wake-up, whenever that is (a bright light on waking helps when the sun isn't an option — and get real sunlight when your schedule allows). The overnight space becomes the over-*day* space. Shift workers arguably need the sleep count most of all — protect the 7 hours fiercely.

Can I split my steps up, or does it have to be one walk?
Steps are steps — the studies count daily totals, not sessions. The morning walk is recommended because it stacks five counts into one act, not because afternoon steps don't count. Park far, take stairs, pace on phone calls. It all lands in the same number.

Is walking really enough? Don't I need to lift weights?
For *this* program — getting started and collecting the first, biggest health returns — walking is plenty to begin with. Should you eventually add strength training? Yes, and my other book makes that case at length (muscle is the substrate that protects your brain as you age). But "eventually" is doing important work in that sentence. Master the counts first. Nothing kills a twelve-week program faster than trying to do everything in week one.

How fast will I lose weight?
I can't give you a date; every body is different. In one small one-meal lab study, extra chewing cut how much people ate by 10–15 percent, but nobody has shown what that adds up to over months. So watch your trend, not the calendar. If the line isn't moving and that bothers you, don't tighten everything.

Check the two counts easiest to fudge, the overnight hours (that 9 p.m. snack) and the fork (is it really going down?), and talk with your clinician if you're concerned.

What should I actually eat?

Anything you're willing to chew 32 times. That's not a dodge — it's the design. This book deliberately doesn't give you a food list, because food lists are where diets go to die. Chew everything, eat in your window, and watch your preferences quietly change on their own. The one food habit worth borrowing now is protein-first when you break the fast (Chapter 11). When you're ready for the full nutrition picture — what to put on the plate and why — that's my other book, *Begin with the End in Mind*, and the free program behind it.

I have diabetes / take medication / am pregnant / have a history of disordered eating. Can I do this?

Talk to your clinician first — specifically about the hours count, which changes when your body receives food and can interact with medication timing, blood-sugar management, and pregnancy. The chewing, the steps, the light, and the sleep counts are safe for nearly everyone. If you have an eating-disorder history, please treat this entire book as something to discuss with your care team before starting; counting of any kind may not be the right tool for you, and that's okay.

I missed three days on vacation. Is it over?

It's not over; it's Tuesday. The streak rule is "never miss twice," and when you've already missed twice, the rule becomes "start a new streak today, at the very next meal." One bite, fork down,

32. You're back. The people who succeed at this aren't the ones who never fall off — they're the ones who restart without holding a funeral first.

Why should I trust a chiropractor about weight loss?
Fair question — ask it of everyone who wants your health attention. My answer: thirty years in clinical practice watching what actually makes people healthier, a career built on assembling specialists rather than pretending one credential covers everything, and — most relevant here — a book that asks you to buy nothing and prints its key sources at the back, where you can read them yourself. Where a number is my own rule of thumb, I've tried to say so.

My partner wants to do this with me. Is anything different for women?
Almost nothing. Steps, light, sleep, and water appear to work for most adults. The one count where physiology can differ is the hours: some women find longer overnight fasts land differently across the menstrual cycle, in perimenopause, or while trying to conceive. If that's you, live at 12 hours a little longer before you climb, and let your body vote at 14 and 16. (Pregnancy is a talk-to-your-clinician case — see above.) Then do it together. In one study of a structured program, people who joined with friends or family and got extra support finished far more often than those who joined alone: 95 percent versus 76.

The Science, Briefly

A plain-language tour of the research behind each count. The key studies are listed in the Sources that follow.

The chew (Chapter 2)

The headline study is a small randomized trial from Iowa State University: when 45 adults increased chews per bite by 50 percent, intake at a single lab lunch dropped about 10 percent; doubling chews dropped it about 15 percent — with no instruction to eat less. A separate review found fast eaters are about twice as likely to have obesity, though that's a link, and slowing down hasn't been proven to fix it. Honest caveat, printed in Chapter 2 and repeated here: in a companion study of 18 older adults, chewing more slowed their eating but did not change how much they ate — which is why chewing is one lever in a stack of six, not a miracle.

The space (Chapter 3)

Eating within a shorter daily window is being studied actively, and the results are mixed. The idea is simple: eating raises insulin; insulin is the storage signal; a longer non-eating stretch gives the body more hours in “spend” mode. In one small study, eight men with prediabetes who ate within an early 6-hour window had better insulin sensitivity and blood pressure, even though the study held their weight steady on purpose. But a larger 12-week trial of a 16-hour overnight fast found people lost no more weight than those eating regular meals. So the hours are one lever in a stack, not a magic window. I like them because they’re free and easy to count. The 3-hours-before-bed count is my own rule of thumb, not a finding from these studies.

The steps (Chapter 4)

A large pooled analysis in the *European Journal of Preventive Cardiology* (17 observational studies, nearly 227,000 adults) linked more steps with lower death rates: all-cause benefits starting around 3,900 steps per day and cardiovascular benefits near 2,300, with risk reduction that tends to be steepest at the low end of the curve. Every additional 500–1,000 daily steps was linked to further protection, with benefits continuing as steps rose. These studies show a link, not proof of cause. The famous 10,000 number itself traces to a Japanese business slogan and walking clubs from the 1960s and ’70s — the science is kinder to beginners than the slogan ever was.

The light (Chapter 5)

Light is the main signal that sets the human body clock. In a small study, eight adults who spent a week camping with only natural light had their internal clocks shift about two hours earlier. And one observational study of office workers found that more morning light went with falling asleep sooner and better sleep quality. These are small studies, so treat the ten minutes as a sensible bet, not a proven dose. Even a gray day outdoors is far brighter than a well-lit room. That gap is why “through a window” doesn’t cut it.

The nights (Chapter 6)

In one small study, 12 healthy young men who slept too little for two nights had more ghrelin (the hunger hormone), less leptin (the fullness hormone), and a bigger appetite, especially for sweet and starchy foods. In a much larger group, people who slept less had higher body weight on average, though that's a link, not proof of cause.

The water (Chapter 7)

In one 12-week trial of 48 overweight middle-aged and older adults, all on a reduced-calorie diet, those who also drank about two cups of water before each meal did better on the scale than those who didn't. That was water on top of a diet, not water alone. Two glasses before noon is inspired by that idea, not proven by it: deliberately modest — a floor designed to be countable, not a hydration religion.

The streak (Chapters 11–12)

In one study, 96 volunteers practiced a new daily habit for 12 weeks. Among those whose data could be charted, the typical person took about 66 days for it to feel automatic, but the range was huge, from about 2.5 weeks to well past the end of the study. A single missed day made little difference, so one slip is no reason to quit. “Never miss twice” is my rule of thumb, not a research finding. As for the scale: studies of people trying to lose weight link regular self-weighing, daily included, with better results and have not found that it harms mood. Once a week is my choice for this book because it’s simple, not because research favors it. Day-to-day numbers bounce with water and food, so watch the trend. Twelve weeks is long enough, for many people, for counting to stop feeling like counting.

Sources

The key studies behind each count, in the order the counts appear.

1. **The chew.** Zhu Y, Hollis JH. Increasing the number of chews before swallowing reduces meal size in normal-weight, overweight, and obese adults. *Journal of the Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics.* 2014;114(6):926–931.
2. **The chew.** Ohkuma T, et al. Association between eating rate and obesity: a systematic review and meta-analysis. *International Journal of Obesity.* 2015;39(11):1589–1596.
3. **The chew.** Zhu Y, Hollis JH. Chewing thoroughly reduces eating rate and postprandial food palatability but does not influence meal size in older adults. *Physiology & Behavior.* 2014;123:62–66.
4. **The space.** Sutton EF, et al. Early time-restricted feeding improves insulin sensitivity, blood pressure, and oxidative stress even without weight loss in men with prediabetes. *Cell Metabolism.* 2018;27(6):1212–1221.e3.
5. **The space.** Lowe DA, et al. Effects of time-restricted eating on weight loss and other metabolic parameters in women and men with overweight and obesity: the TREAT randomized clinical trial. *JAMA Internal Medicine.* 2020;180(11):1491–1499.
6. **The steps.** Banach M, et al. The association between daily step count and all-cause and cardiovascular mortality: a meta-analysis. *European Journal of Preventive Cardiology.* 2023;30(18):1975–1985.
7. **The steps.** Tudor-Locke C, Bassett DR. How many steps/day are enough? Preliminary pedometer indices for public health. *Sports Medicine.* 2004;34(1):1–8.
8. **The light.** Wright KP, et al. Entrainment of the human circadian clock to the natural light-dark cycle. *Current Biology.* 2013;23(16):1554–1558.

9. **The light.** Figueiro MG, et al. The impact of daytime light exposures on sleep and mood in office workers. *Sleep Health*. 2017;3(3):204–215.
10. **The nights.** Spiegel K, Tasali E, Penev P, Van Cauter E. Sleep curtailment in healthy young men is associated with decreased leptin levels, elevated ghrelin levels, and increased hunger and appetite. *Annals of Internal Medicine*. 2004;141(11):846–850.
11. **The nights.** Taheri S, et al. Short sleep duration is associated with reduced leptin, elevated ghrelin, and increased body mass index. *PLoS Medicine*. 2004;1(3):e62.
12. **The water.** Dennis EA, et al. Water consumption increases weight loss during a hypocaloric diet intervention in middle-aged and older adults. *Obesity*. 2010;18(2):300–307.
13. **The streak.** Lally P, van Jaarsveld CHM, Potts HWW, Wardle J. How are habits formed: modelling habit formation in the real world. *European Journal of Social Psychology*. 2010;40(6):998–1009.
14. **The scale.** Steinberg DM, et al. Daily self-weighing and adverse psychological outcomes: a randomized controlled trial. *American Journal of Preventive Medicine*. 2014;46(1):24–29.
15. **The scale.** Zheng Y, et al. Self-weighing in weight management: a systematic literature review. *Obesity*. 2015;23(2):256–265.
16. **Doing it together.** Wing RR, Jeffery RW. Benefits of recruiting participants with friends and increasing social support for weight loss and maintenance. *Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology*. 1999;67(1):132–138.

Week 13 and Forever

There is no Week 13 log printed in this book, on purpose. By now the counts may live in you. If you'd still like the pen, the next page has a free log. Two counts are all you need to keep.

The maintenance program is two counts, kept for life:

1. **The morning walk.** Five boxes, one act, every day it's possible.
2. **The 32.** Every meal, every table, forever. It's free, it's invisible, and it's the reason the food scale stays in the drawer.

Keep the weekly weigh-in — same scale, same morning — as your smoke alarm. If the trend line drifts three weeks running, you know exactly which counts slipped, and you know they're all waiting where you left them: at the very next meal, and out the front door tomorrow morning.

Your Free Count Log

Some people like to keep writing it down. If that's you, the next log is free.

It's a printable page in the same format as the weekly log in this book, plus the counts on one page. Print as many as you need, one for each week, from Week 13 on.

Go to my4mlife.com/go/count-yourself-skinny. Leave your email and the download is yours, right there on the page. It costs nothing. You'll also get updates and offers from My4MLife, and you can unsubscribe anytime.

You don't need it. The walk and the 32 are plenty, and a sticky note works fine. But if a page on the refrigerator keeps you showing up, it's yours.

Give the Count Away

This book was priced and sized to be given away — that's the design, not an accident.

The counts spread the way they were taught: one person, one meal, one "why is your fork down?" at a time. If this book moved your scale:

- **Hand this copy to someone.** You have the counts memorized now; you don't need the paper.
- **The one-page summary is free to photograph and share.** Refrigerators, break rooms, church bulletin boards — go ahead.
- **Doing it with someone can help you both finish.** Buy one for the person who'll walk with you.

For bulk copies — teams, clinics, churches, workplaces — write to **support@my4mlife.com**.

Notes

About the Author

Dr. TJ is the founder of My4MLife. A former Texas Tech track-and-field record-holder turned chiropractor, he has spent thirty years assembling teams of varied specialists under one roof to deliver outcomes no single discipline can — and testing every protocol on himself first. His larger work on cognitive longevity, *Begin with the End in Mind*, and the free program built around it live at my4mlife.com.

This book is the doorway. Everything in it is free to do, starting at your next meal.

This book is for educational purposes only and is not medical advice. Consult a licensed clinician before beginning any change to diet, fasting schedule, or exercise, particularly if you take medication, are pregnant, have diabetes, or have a history of disordered eating.